

Case Study: Harper Fitness - Implementation of a technology refresh

Nature of the business

Harper Fitness is a global chain of gyms and wellness centres. Founded in 2001 by former athletes Chris and Maria Harper, the company began as a small independent gym in Brisbane, Australia, offering personal training and group classes. Over time, it expanded into a network of full-service fitness centres across Australia, New Zealand, the UK, and Canada.

Now employing more than 12,000 staff worldwide, Harper Fitness offers a range of services to its members, including:

- Gym memberships: Access to fully equipped fitness centres, including weights, cardio equipment, and pools.
- Personal training packages: One-on-one or small group training sessions tailored to fitness goals.
- Group classes: Yoga, Pilates, HIIT, spin, and functional training delivered by certified instructors.
- Wellness programs: Nutrition coaching, mental health workshops, and corporate health partnerships.

Headquartered in Brisbane, Harper Fitness operates over 400 centres globally. It has developed strong brand recognition in the wellness market due to its emphasis on affordability, community-based health programs, and partnerships with local sporting clubs.

Customer Profile and the Role of Fitfluencers

Historically, Harper Fitness attracted members aged 25 to 55 who valued affordability, convenient locations, and reliable services. These customers typically joined through traditional channels such as local advertising, workplace programs, and word-of-mouth referrals. Practical considerations such as price, proximity, and class schedules were central to their decision-making.

In recent years, the organisation has seen growth in members aged 18–30. This group is more likely to engage with fitness brands through digital channels, particularly social media platforms such as TikTok and Instagram. Some prospective members encounter Harper Fitness through fitness-related content, including posts created by influencers who share workouts, routines, and experiences within gym environments.

This younger cohort is generally more comfortable with digital technology and expects convenient online access to services such as class bookings, training plans, and membership management. They are also more likely to track and share aspects of their fitness journeys online.

At the same time, research in consumer behaviour suggests that audience responses to influencer content can vary. While visually appealing content can attract attention, relatability plays an important role in sustaining engagement. Audiences tend to respond more positively to content that feels realistic and achievable, particularly in a fitness context where personal goals and self-perception are relevant.

For Harper Fitness, this shift highlights the importance of balancing aspirational and relatable messaging. While some members are motivated by high-performance imagery, others may prefer content that reflects a broader range of experiences and fitness levels. This suggests that a more diverse and balanced approach to digital content may better support engagement across different customer segments.

Business Challenges

Harper Fitness faces a dual challenge. On one hand, its information technology infrastructure is dated and limits its ability to serve members through digital channels. On the other hand, its current use of fitfluencers and visual branding may not align with emerging evidence about what actually drives engagement online.

The IT department is small and underfunded. Four staff members support core back-office systems such as payroll, staff scheduling and the membership database. The public website was originally built in the early 2000s and has seen only incremental updates. It is largely static and provides basic information: gym locations, class timetables, membership pricing and contact details. It is not fully mobile-optimised, offers only minimal online joining functionality, and does not integrate with social media in any meaningful way.

Unlike many competitors, Harper Fitness does not yet have a comprehensive mobile application. Class bookings are largely made by phone or at reception, and digital check-in is limited or non-existent. Members cannot easily manage their memberships online, access tailored training plans or view their class history. This is increasingly frustrating for younger customers who expect seamless, app-based experiences as standard.

At the same time, Harper Fitness continues to invest in social media campaigns centred on fitfluencers. In practice, however, the marketing team has begun to see mixed results. Some campaigns fitfluencers attract high initial views but comparatively low sustained engagement, shares and sign-ups. Feedback from certain members, especially beginners or those returning to exercise, suggests that such content can feel intimidating or demotivating. They perceive the influencers as “not like me” and the goals portrayed as unrealistic.

The lack of integrated data means that IT, marketing and operations are often working in silos. Marketing cannot easily trace a path from an Instagram campaign through to website visits, app usage (where pilot apps exist) or membership sales. Regional managers see only local membership numbers and occasionally anecdotal feedback but have limited visibility into the digital drivers of those outcomes. As a result, Harper Fitness risks misallocating its marketing budget towards visually impressive but less effective campaigns in terms of converting social media into actual memberships.

Business Opportunity

Despite these challenges, the situation presents a significant opportunity for Harper Fitness to re-think both its technology environment and its digital engagement strategy. The company sees a chance to modernise its digital platforms, harness data more effectively and align its use of fitfluencers with evidence about relatability and connection.

Harper Fitness is considering a comprehensive technology refresh. A key component is a complete redesign of the public website. The new site would be mobile-responsive, visually modern and built around clear user journeys for prospective and current members. Potential customers would be able to explore facilities, read about classes, sign up for trials or full memberships, and access introductory programmes tailored to their goals and starting fitness level. Members would log in to a secure area to manage memberships, update payment details, view class history and access online resources.

Also, Harper Fitness wants to develop a mobile application to act as the primary hub for member interactions. Through the app, members could book and cancel classes, check in at clubs using QR codes, and track workouts. The app would integrate with wearables such as smart watches and fitness trackers to log activity and provide feedback. Over time, it could support personalised training plans, nudges and reminders, and community features such as challenges and leader boards.

Request for Proposal

Harper Fitness is seeking proposals from consultancies to deliver this technology refresh. Specifically, Harper Fitness wants a partner who understands how to build modern, scalable digital platforms. Harper Fitness sees an opportunity to transform its digital presence by investing in a technology refresh.

Proposed initiatives include:

- A complete refresh of the Harper Fitness website with modern design and user experience.
- A mobile application for booking classes, managing memberships, and integrating with wearables.
- A 24/7 chatbot to provide instant support for members online.
- Enhanced online wellness services, including digital coaching, class streaming, and nutrition tracking.

Rival brands like F45 and Anytime Fitness already provide integrated mobile apps with booking and tracking functionality. Without change, Harper Fitness risks reputational decline and member attrition.

Constraints and Expectations

The project must be delivered within 12–15 months, with a refreshed online presence launched within six months. Budget allocation is capped at \$6 million AUD.

Senior management is seeking measurable improvements in customer satisfaction and membership uptake among 18–30-year-olds by investing in a technology refresh such as this project.

The Assignment

Your consulting organisation has decided to respond to the RFP. As the Director on your team, it has fallen to you to lead the response.

You will need to prepare the response in consideration Harper's Gyms request – i.e. to cover what their business problem is and how you will execute the implementation of a technology refresh. The structure of the proposal should follow and incorporate the standard flow that your consultancy's proposals typically follow:

- Executive summary
- Introduction
- Our understand of your needs
- Engagement methodology and timelines (including risk management and governance)
- Pricing and assumptions
- Team CVs
- Similar work we have performed